

Abigail (Abby) Cassario, PhD

Postdoctoral Research Associate, Department of Psychology
University of Illinois Chicago
1007 W. Harrison St.
Chicago, IL 60607

Phone: 919-309-5422

Email: cassario@uic.edu

URL: abigailcassario.github.io

Academic Appointments

- 2026– *Postdoctoral Research Associate*, Belief Identity and Group Relations Lab,
Department of Psychology, University of Illinois Chicago
- 2022–2026 *Graduate Student*, The Belief Systems Lab, Department of Psychology, Michigan State University

Research Interests

Beliefs, Belief Systems, Ideology, Attitudes, Persuasion, Computational Social Science

Teaching Interests

Social Psychology, Personality Psychology, Political Psychology, Political Behavior, Introductory Psychology, Attitudes & Persuasion, Moral Psychology, Beliefs & Misinformation, Psychology of Prejudice, Research Methods/Statistics, Computational Social Science

Education

- 2026 Ph.D. in Social/Personality Psychology, Michigan State University
- 2021 M.A. in Political Science, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill
- 2019 B.A. in Political Science and Psychology, University of North Carolina at Asheville (Summa Cum Laude)

Grants & Fellowships

- 2026 \$4,600 Institute for Humane Studies Residency Grant. *Project: Falling Short? Testing the Causal Effect of Downward Mobility on Anti-Democratic Attitudes*
- 2026 \$7,500 Michigan State University Dissertation Completion Fellowship (Summer 2026). *Project: Falling Short? Testing the Causal Effect of Downward Mobility on Populist Support*
- 2025 \$1,000 Michigan State University Research Enhancement Award. *Project: Exploring the Effect of Threat Exposure on Political Ideology*

2025	\$5,000 <i>Co-Investigator</i> , Institute for Humane Studies (IHS) Grant (with Mark Brandt, PI). <i>Project: Testing Side Effects of Polarization Reduction Interventions</i>
2025	PolNet–PaCSS 2025 Graduate Student Fellowship
2025	Summer Institute in Social and Personality Psychology (attendee)
2022–2023	MSU Graduate Merit Assistantship
2019–2024	UNC Chapel Hill Department of Political Science Thomas Uhlman Fellowship (declined, 2022–2024)
2019	UNC Chapel Hill Graduate Merit Assistantship

Honors & Awards

2025	SPSP Student Publication Award for Best Graduate Student Publication in an SPSP Journal (for Cassario & Brandt, 2025)
------	---

Research

[†]Denotes mentored undergraduate student

PEER REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

2026	Triki, A. [†] , Cassario, A. L. , & Brandt, M. J.. American liberals and conservatives have different cognitive styles, but (mostly) respond the same to party cues. <i>Journal of Experimental Social Psychology</i> . (in press).
2025	Thompson, J. L., Cassario, A. L. , Rice, S., Gnall, S. A., Carrillo, A., Solanki, P., Vallabha, S., Brandt, M. J., & Wetherell, G. (2025). Registered report: Stress testing predictive models of ideological prejudice. <i>PLOS One</i> , 20(10), e0334152.
2025	Wetherell, G., Thompson, J. L., Cassario, A. L. , Brandt, M. J., Gnall, S., Rice, S., Solanki, P., Vallabha, S., & Carrillo, A. (2025). Do mismatches between individual and target group personality predict prejudice? <i>Collabra: Psychology</i> , 11, 136887.
2025	Cassario, A. L. , Vallabha, S., Thompson, J. L., Carrillo, A., Solanki, P., Gnall, S. A., Wetherell, G., & Brandt, M. J. (2025). Registered report: Cognitive ability, but not cognitive reflection, predicts expressing greater political animosity and favouritism. <i>British Journal of Social Psychology</i> , 64(2), e12814.
2025	Cassario, A. L. , & Brandt, M. J. (2025). Testing theories of threat, individual difference, and ideology: Little evidence of personality-based individual differences in ideological responses to threat. <i>Social Psychological and Personality Science</i> , 16(6), 657–668‡

‡ Recipient of the SPSP Student Publication Award for Best Graduate Student Publication in an SPSP Journal, 2025.

2023 **Cassario, A. L.** (2023). Perceived vulnerability to infectious disease and perceived harmfulness are as predictive of citizen response to COVID-19 as partisanship. *Politics and the Life Sciences*, 42(2), 277–290.

2019 Cox, K. S., Hanek, K. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (2019). Redemption in a single low point story longitudinally predicts well-being: The incremental validity of life story elements. *Journal of Personality*, 87(5), 1009–1024.

EDITOR REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

2023 Brandt, M. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (2023). Distinguishing between worldview conflict and shared alliances: Commentary on Pinsof, Sears, and Haselton. *Psychological Inquiry*, 34(3), 168–174.

UNDER REVISION

2026 **Cassario, A. L.**, Vallabha, S., & Brandt, M. J. (Invited resubmission). Central attitudes are more resistant to change, but are not necessarily less responsive to persuasive interventions. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*.

2026 Cameron, C. D., **Cassario, A. L.**, Eadeh, F., Floman, J., Kubin, E., Laurent, S., Pasek, M. H., Phillips, J., & Schumann, K. (Revise and resubmit). Political divisions and the security of empathy. *Political Psychology*.

SELECTED CURRENT PROJECTS

2026 **Cassario, A. L.**, Triki, A.[†], & Brandt, M. J. (Manuscript in preparation). Does Threat Exposure Increase Conservatism? Evidence for Terrorism-Specific but Not General Causal Effects.

2025 **Cassario, A. L.**, & Brandt, M. J. (Manuscript in preparation). Conviction cascades: Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties.

2025 Brandt, M. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (Manuscript in preparation). Within-person fluctuations in daily stress do not predict political prejudice or engagement, but higher between-person stress does: Evidence from an EMA study.

2025 Brandt, M. J., & **Cassario, A. L.** (Manuscript in preparation). Side effects of depolarization interventions.

2025 **Cassario, A. L.** (In data collection). Exploring the relationship between downward mobility and anti-establishment attitudes.

Invited Talks

- 2026 Cassario, A. L. (2026, Spring). Exploring new insights into political belief dynamics. University of Illinois Chicago, Chicago, IL.
- 2025 Cassario, A. L. (2025, Spring). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Invited talk at the Interdisciplinary Consortium on Moral Decision Making, Pennsylvania State University, State College, PA.
- 2025 Cassario, A. L. (2025, Spring). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Invited talk at the Inequality Working Group Meeting (virtual).

Conference Symposia (Organized)

- 2026 Cassario, A. L. (Chair). *Moral Minds in Polarized Times*. Symposium presented at the Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP) Annual Convention, Chicago, IL, February 2026. *Includes my talk: Conviction Cascades: Moral Conviction Transmits Through Belief System Ties.*

Selected Conference Presentations

- 2026 Cassario, A. L., Vallabha, S., & Brandt, M. J. (2026, May). Central attitudes in political belief systems are more resistant to change, but not necessarily less amenable to targeted persuasive attempts. *Midwest Political Science Association*, Chicago, IL.
- 2026 Cassario, A. L., Vallabha, S., & Brandt, M. J. (2026, February). Central attitudes in political belief systems are more resistant to change, but not necessarily less amenable to targeted persuasive attempts. Spotlight early career data blitz, *SPSP Computational Psychology Preconference*, Chicago, IL.
- 2025 Cassario, A. L., & Brandt, M. J. (2025, December). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Poster presented at *MIT Directions of Polarization, Norms, and Trust in Societies*, Cambridge, MA.
- 2025 Cassario, A. L., & Brandt, M. J. (2025, August). Moral conviction transmits through belief system ties. Poster presented at the *PolNet–PaCSS Conference*, Cambridge, MA.
- 2025 Cassario, A. L., & Brandt, M. J. (2025, February). Mapping individual level belief systems. Poster presented at the *Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP) Annual Convention*, Denver, CO.
- 2024 Cassario, A. L., & Brandt, M. J. (2024, February). Testing theories of threat, individual difference, and ideology: Little evidence of personality-based individual differences in ideological responses to threat. Poster presented at the *Society for Personality and Social Psychology (SPSP) Annual Convention*, San Diego, CA.

2022

Cassario, A. L. (2022, April). Not all motivated reasoning is partisan: Personality and harm perceptions limit the influence of partisanship in shaping citizens' perceptions of COVID-19. Paper presented at the *Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) Annual Meeting*, Chicago, IL.

Teaching Experience

Introduction to Social Psychology (MSU, instructor of record)

Introduction to Personality Psychology (MSU, TA, grader)

Psychology of Women (MSU, TA, grader)

Introduction to R Programming and Statistics (MSU, TA, section instructor; UNC, TA, grader)

Introduction to American Politics (UNC, TA, section instructor)

Race, Innocence and the Death Penalty (UNC, TA, section instructor)

Mentorship

2026

Led the Belief Systems Lab Undergraduate Research Program, Spring 2026

Mentored teams through project design, analysis, and presentation at the MSU University Undergraduate Research and Arts Forum (UURAF).

"To what extent does your social group (or "close others") agree or disagree with your political views?" by Genevieve Orlewicz, Nicole Thomas, & Peyton McLaughlin — *First place prize in section, best research presentation in psychology, UURAF Spring 2026*

"Does your social group influence how open you are to differing political views?" by Genevieve Orlewicz, Nicole Thomas, & Peyton McLaughlin — *Second place prize in section, best research presentation in psychology, UURAF, Spring 2026*

"The relationship between religion and media trust" by Emma Dye — *Third place prize in section, best research presentation in psychology, UURAF Spring 2026*

"How country pride affects immigrants' life satisfaction" by Madeline Hilditch & Mina Arian, *UURAF Spring 2026*

Professional Service

2023–2024

Graduate Student Advisory Committee (GSAC), Social/Personality Area Representative, Michigan State University Department of Psychology

Ad-hoc Reviewer

American Journal of Political Science

Analysis of Social Issues and Public Policy

British Journal of Social Psychology

Journal of Personality
Journal of Personality and Social Psychology
Legislative Studies Quarterly
Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin
Political Behavior
Politics and the Life Sciences
Psychological Science
Social Psychological and Personality Science

Computer Skills

R (Advanced)
Qualtrics (Advanced)
High-Performance Computing (MSU HPCC; SLURM) (Intermediate)
SAS (Intermediate)
SPSS (Intermediate)
MATLAB (Beginner)
GitHub (Beginner)
Python (Beginner)
L^AT_EX

References

Mark Brandt, Professor of Psychology, Tilburg University, m.j.brandt@tilburguniversity.edu
Jennifer Wolak, Professor of Political Science, Michigan State University, wolakjen@msu.edu
Tedmond Schwaba, Assistant Professor of Psychology, Michigan State University, schwabat@msu.edu